The idea is much more convincing than it seems on first reading. We can say that we measure duration with a clock. But to do so requires us to read it at two different moments: this is not possible, because we are always in one moment, never in two. In the present, we see only the present; we can see things that we interpret as *traces* of the past, but there is a categorical difference between seeing traces of the past and perceiving the flow of time—and Augustine realizes that the root of this difference, the awareness of the passing of time, is internal. It is integral to the mind. It is the traces left in the brain by the past.

Augustine's exposition of the idea is quite beautiful. It is based on our experience of music. When we listen to a hymn, the meaning of a sound is given by the ones that come before and after it. Music can occur only in time, but if we are always in the present moment, how is it possible to hear it? It is possible, Augustine observes, because our consciousness is based on memory and on anticipation. A hymn, a song, is in some way present in our minds in a unified form, held together by something—by that which we take time to be. And hence this is what time is: it is entirely in the present, in our minds, as memory and as anticipation.

The idea that time might exist only in the mind certainly did not become dominant in Christian thought. In fact, it is one of the propositions explicitly condemned as heretical by Étienne Tempier, the Bishop of Paris, in 1277. In his list of beliefs to be condemned, the following can be found:

> *Quod evum et tempus nichil sunt in re, Sed solum in apprehensione.*[112]

In other words: "[It is heretical to maintain that] the age and time do not exist in reality but only in the mind." Perhaps my book is sliding toward heresy. . . . But given that Augustine continues to be regarded as a saint, I don't suppose that I should be too worried about it. Christianity, after all, is quite flexible. . . .

It may seem easy to refute Augustine by arguing that the traces of the past that he finds within himself may be there only because they reflect a real structure of the external world. In the fourteenth century, for instance, William of Ockham maintained in his *Philosophiae Naturalis* that man observes both the sky's movements and the ones within himself and therefore perceives time through his coexistence with the world. Centuries later, Edmond Husserl insists—rightly—on the distinction between physical time and "internal consciousness of time": for a sound naturalist wishing to avoid drowning in the useless vortices of idealism, the former (the physical world) comes first, while the latter (consciousness)—independently of how well we